Cloud and Fog Computing for IoT
(CS4001)

CIA-2

Question 2: Latency-Aware Task Scheduling and Load Balancing in Fog Computing

Docker image: **https://hub.docker.com/r/shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog** (v1, latest)

GitHub repo link: **https://github.com/Shakthe/cfccia** (folder **cia2/**)

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1. Introduction

In CIA-1 I built **VitalWatch**, a cloud system that checks a patient's vital signs and sends an alert back to their wearable. Everything there went to the cloud. That works, but every reading has to travel over the internet and back, and in a hospital with many patients the internet link becomes the slow point. For a heart-rate or SpO2 alert, a delay of a few hundred milliseconds is too much.

For CIA-2 I moved VitalWatch to a **fog** design. Small computers inside the hospital (one per ward, plus one hospital server) do the urgent work close to the patient, and only the heavy work goes to the cloud. The hard part is deciding *where each task should run*. So the main work of this assignment is a scheduler I call **LAPS (Latency-Aware Priority Scheduler)**. For every task it looks at priority, deadline, expected latency, CPU load, network bandwidth and energy, and then picks the local fog node, another fog node, or the cloud.

I tested LAPS in two ways:

- A **simulator** I wrote in Python. It runs a hospital of 50 to 300 patients and compares LAPS with four common methods: FCFS, Round Robin, Min-Min and cloud-only. Each setting runs 5 times with different random seeds.
- A **live testbed** in Docker: three fog-node containers of different sizes, a cloud container behind a real 70 ms network delay, and the scheduler gateway, with simulated wearables sending real tasks.

The tasks come in three types:

Task type	Priority	Size (MI)	Data	Deadline	How often (per patient)
Critical vitals check (HR, SpO2, BP, temp)	P1	30 – 70	1 – 2 KB	100 ms	every 1 s
ECG window analysis (10 s of ECG)	P2	300 – 700	10 – 20 KB	1 s	every 10 s
Bulk job (24 h trend, risk model, report)	P3	4000 – 12000	200 – 400 KB	10 s	every 5 min

2. Literature Survey

I read 13 papers on fog task scheduling, load balancing, latency-aware computing and resource allocation. For some of them I could only get the abstract, so the table below only lists what each paper actually reports.

#	Paper	Algorithm / approach	Simulation / dataset	Metrics	Result	Limitation
1	Gupta et al., 2017 [1]	iFogSim toolkit; edge-ward module placement vs cloud-only	iFogSim (EEG game, camera surveillance)	latency, network use, energy, cost	edge-ward gave lower latency and much lower network use than cloud-only	static placement; no priority, deadlines or load balancing between fog nodes
2	Mahmud et al., 2019 [2]	latency-aware placement of application modules	iFogSim	deadline satisfaction, resource use	better than other latency-aware strategies (no figure given in abstract)	module placement, not per-task scheduling; energy and priority not covered
3	Bitam et al., 2018 [3]	Bees Life Algorithm (metaheuristic)	own experiments	CPU execution time, memory	beat PSO and GA	ignores network latency, deadlines, energy and cloud offload
4	Pham & Huh, 2016 [4]	heuristic for cloud-fog scheduling	numerical study	makespan, cloud cost	better makespan-cost trade-off	no deadlines, priority or energy
5	Deng et al., 2016 [5]	optimisation: split workload between fog and cloud	numerical simulation	power, delay, bandwidth	fog cuts delay and bandwidth use	works on total workload, not each task; no priority
6	Jamil et al., 2020 [6]	delay-aware fog job scheduler	iFogSim	delay, network usage	32% lower delay and 16% lower network use than FCFS	only FCFS as baseline; no cloud spill or priority classes reported
7	Aladwani, 2019 [7]	TCVC: tasks put into 3 importance classes by patient status, on top of MAX-MIN	CloudSim	execution, waiting and finish time	improves static scheduling	static; no live load, bandwidth, energy or cloud offload
8	Khattak et al., 2019 [8]	rule-based: forward to a nearby fog server when overloaded; critical data to cloud	15,000 jobs, 10 fog devices (iFogSim-style)	processing time, power, response time	trends shown in figures	no baseline comparison; binary criticality; no deadlines

9	Talaat et al., 2020 [9]	LBOS: reinforcement learning + genetic algorithm load balancing	healthcare IoT-fog-cloud system	allocation cost, response time, balance level	best load-balancing level, 85.71%	no priority classes, deadlines or energy mentioned
10	Tuli et al., 2020 [10]	HealthFog: deep-learning diagnosis on FogBus; least-loaded worker, else cloud	real Raspberry Pi testbed, Cleveland heart dataset	accuracy, latency, power, bandwidth	ensemble raised accuracy by 16%	scheduling only uses a load threshold
11	Hussein & Mousa, 2020 [11]	ant colony and particle swarm task offloading	MATLAB, 200–2000 sensors, 8–20 fog nodes	response time, degree of imbalance	ACO beat PSO and Round Robin	energy not in objective; static scenarios; no priority
12	Hoang & Dang, 2017 [12]	FBRC: integer program + heuristic over fog regions and cloud	custom numerical simulation	completion / response time	beat region-only and cloud-only	no energy or priority; node state assumed known
13	Abdelmoneem et al., 2020 [13]	MobMBAR: ranks tasks by critical level and max response time, with mobility handoff	simulated hospital building	makespan, energy, missed tasks	88% lower makespan, 92% lower energy	live CPU load and bandwidth not mentioned in abstract

What I learnt and the research gap

- Healthcare priority is used in a few papers, but only as fixed classes [7], a single heart-rate threshold [8], or a ranking for makespan [13].
- Load balancing is often one simple threshold ([8], [10]) or a heavy optimiser such as ACO, RL or bees ([3], [9], [11]) that leaves energy or deadlines out.
- The delay-energy trade-off is studied for the total workload [5], not task by task.
- Many papers compare only against FCFS or cloud-only, and few show what happens as the number of patients grows.

Gap: none of these papers makes one per-task decision that uses priority, deadline, live CPU load, link bandwidth and energy together, spills to a nearby fog node before going to the cloud, and is tested across growing healthcare load against several baselines. LAPS is my attempt at exactly that.

3. System Architecture

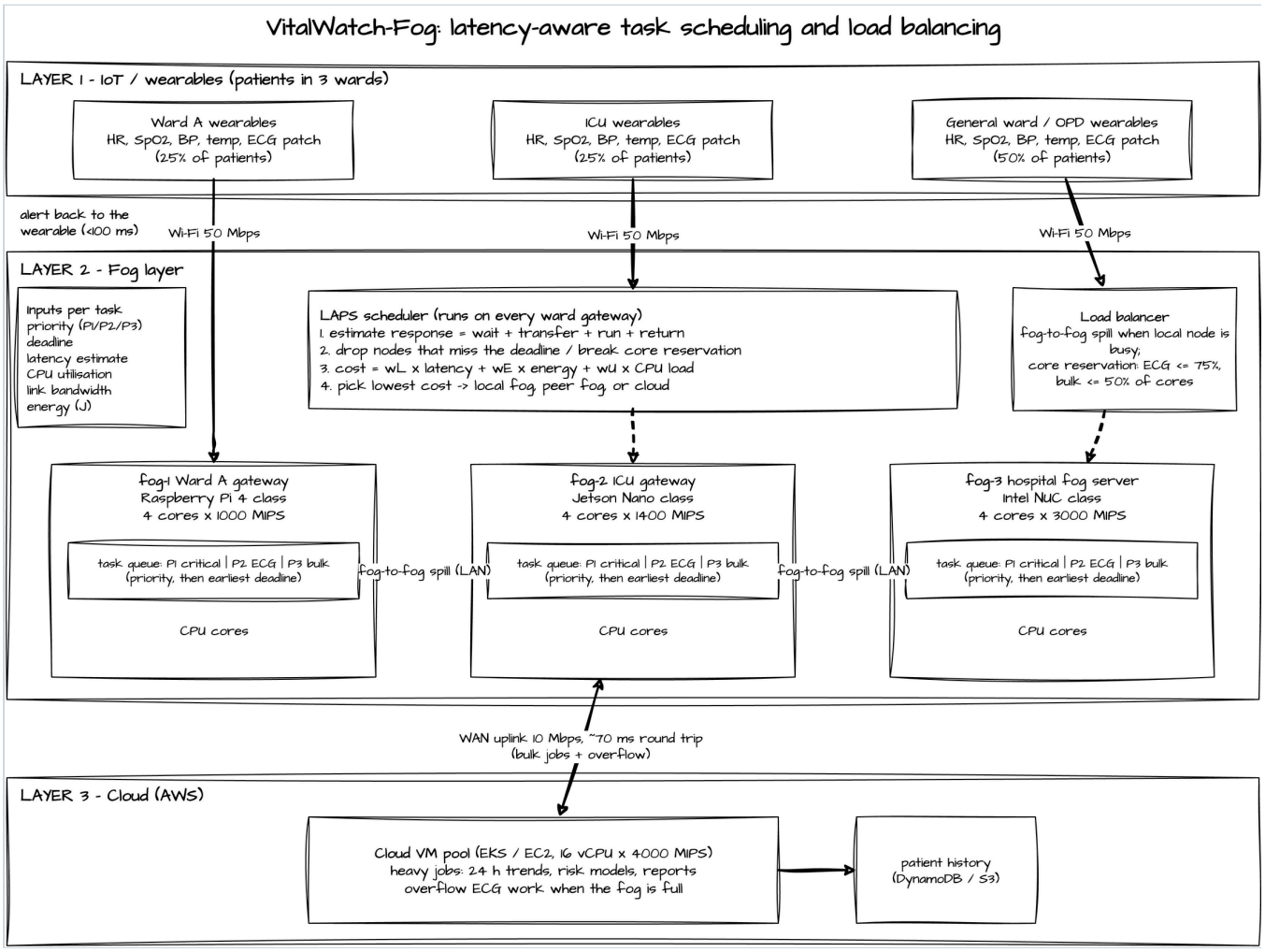


Figure 3.1 — VitalWatch-Fog architecture: wearables, fog nodes with task queues, the LAPS scheduler and load balancer, and the AWS cloud

Layer	What is there	What it does
1 — IoT	Wearables in three wards	Send vitals every second, ECG windows every 10 s and data for bulk jobs every 5 minutes, over Wi-Fi to their ward gateway
2 — Fog	fog-1 (Pi 4 class), fog-2 (Jetson class), fog-3 (NUC class), each with a priority task queue	The ward gateway runs LAPS and picks a node. Each node runs P1 tasks first, then P2, then P3; inside one class the earliest deadline goes first. Busy nodes pass work to a peer fog node over the 100 Mbps LAN
3 — Cloud	AWS VM pool (EKS/EC2) and storage	Runs the heavy jobs and any ECG work the fog cannot fit; keeps patient history. Reached over a 10 Mbps uplink with about 70 ms round trip

4. Scheduling Parameters

Parameter	How I measure it	How LAPS uses it
Latency	estimated response = time already spent + max(transfer, queue wait) + run time + return time	nodes that would miss 90% of the deadline are dropped; the rest pay a latency cost
Task priority	P1 critical, P2 ECG, P3 bulk	sets the queue order and the weights
CPU utilisation	busy cores ÷ total cores on each node	load term in the cost; core reservation
Network bandwidth	bits already waiting on the link ÷ link speed (Wi-Fi 50, LAN 100, WAN 10 Mbps)	part of the transfer time, so a busy uplink makes the cloud look slower
Deadline	100 ms / 1 s / 10 s	hard filter, and earliest-deadline order inside a queue
Energy	run time × watts per core + bits × energy per bit of each link	energy term in the cost

The queue wait is worked out by spreading the work already ahead of the task over the node's cores as they become free. A running task always counts, because tasks are never stopped half-way.

5. The LAPS Algorithm

```
for each new task t at its ward gateway:
    for each node n in {fog-1, fog-2, fog-3, cloud}:
        R(n) = elapsed + max(transfer(n), wait(n)) + run(n) + return(n)
        E(n) = run(n) x watts(n) + bits x energy_per_bit(path)
        U(n) = busy cores / cores
    keep n only if  R(n) <= 0.9 x deadline
                and (n is cloud or core reservation allows t)
    if nothing is left:
        P1 -> node with the smallest R(n);  P2/P3 -> cloud
    else:
        cost(n) = wL x R(n)/deadline + wE x E(n)/max E + wU x U(n)
        send t to the node with the lowest cost
```

Priority	wL (latency)	wE (energy)	wU (load)	Core reservation on a fog node
P1 critical	0.5	0.3	0.2	may use every core
P2 ECG	0.4	0.35	0.25	ECG + bulk together at most 75% of cores
P3 bulk	0.2	0.4	0.4	bulk at most 50% of cores

The reservation is the load-balancing part I care about most. A 10-second bulk job on a Pi can block a core for 8 seconds. If all cores fill up with such jobs, a critical alert has to wait. Keeping some cores free for urgent work, and sending the overflow to a peer fog node or the cloud, avoids that.

6. Implementation and Setup

All code is in the `cia2/` folder of the repo:

- `fogsim/` has the simulator. `policies.py` holds LAPS and the four baselines, and the same code is used by the live gateway.
- `testbed/` has the fog node, gateway and wearable programs.
- `docker-compose.yml` starts the testbed.

6.1 Simulator

The simulator is a discrete-event simulator. Each patient sends tasks as random (Poisson) arrivals at the rates in Section 1. Links are shared queues with a speed and a delay, and nodes have cores and a queue. Each run covers 300 s; I ignore the first 30 s while the system warms up. Every setting ran with 5 seeds, 225 runs in total.

Node	Cores × MIPS	Extra watts per busy core
fog-1 Ward A gateway (Raspberry Pi 4 class)	4 × 1000	0.93 W
fog-2 ICU gateway (Jetson Nano class)	4 × 1400	2.0 W
fog-3 hospital fog server (Intel NUC class)	4 × 3000	8.75 W
Cloud VM pool	16 × 4000	12 W (8 W × PUE 1.5)

The four baselines:

- **FCFS:** every task runs on its own ward gateway, in arrival order.
- **Round Robin:** tasks go to fog-1, fog-2, fog-3 and the cloud in turn.
- **Min-Min (MCT):** the online form of Min-Min, picking the node with the earliest completion time, with FIFO queues.
- **Cloud only:** everything goes to the cloud.

6.2 Live Docker testbed

I packed everything into one image, `shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1`. The `ROLE` variable picks node, gateway, wearables or sim.

- Every task burns real CPU (SHA-256 rounds) in proportion to its size.
- Compose gives the fog containers different CPU shares (0.6, 1.0 and 2.0 CPUs), so fog-1 really is slower. Each node times itself when it starts.

- A small sidecar uses Linux `tc netem` to put 70 ms ± 10 ms of delay on the cloud container's network, like a real WAN.

```
$ docker build -t shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1 -t shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:latest .
...
Step 12/13 : HEALTHCHECK --interval=30s --timeout=5s --retries=3   CMD python -c "import
urllib..."
Step 13/13 : ENTRYPOINT ["testbed/entrypoint.sh"]
Successfully built 036b86c9d6ee
Successfully tagged shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1
Successfully tagged shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:latest

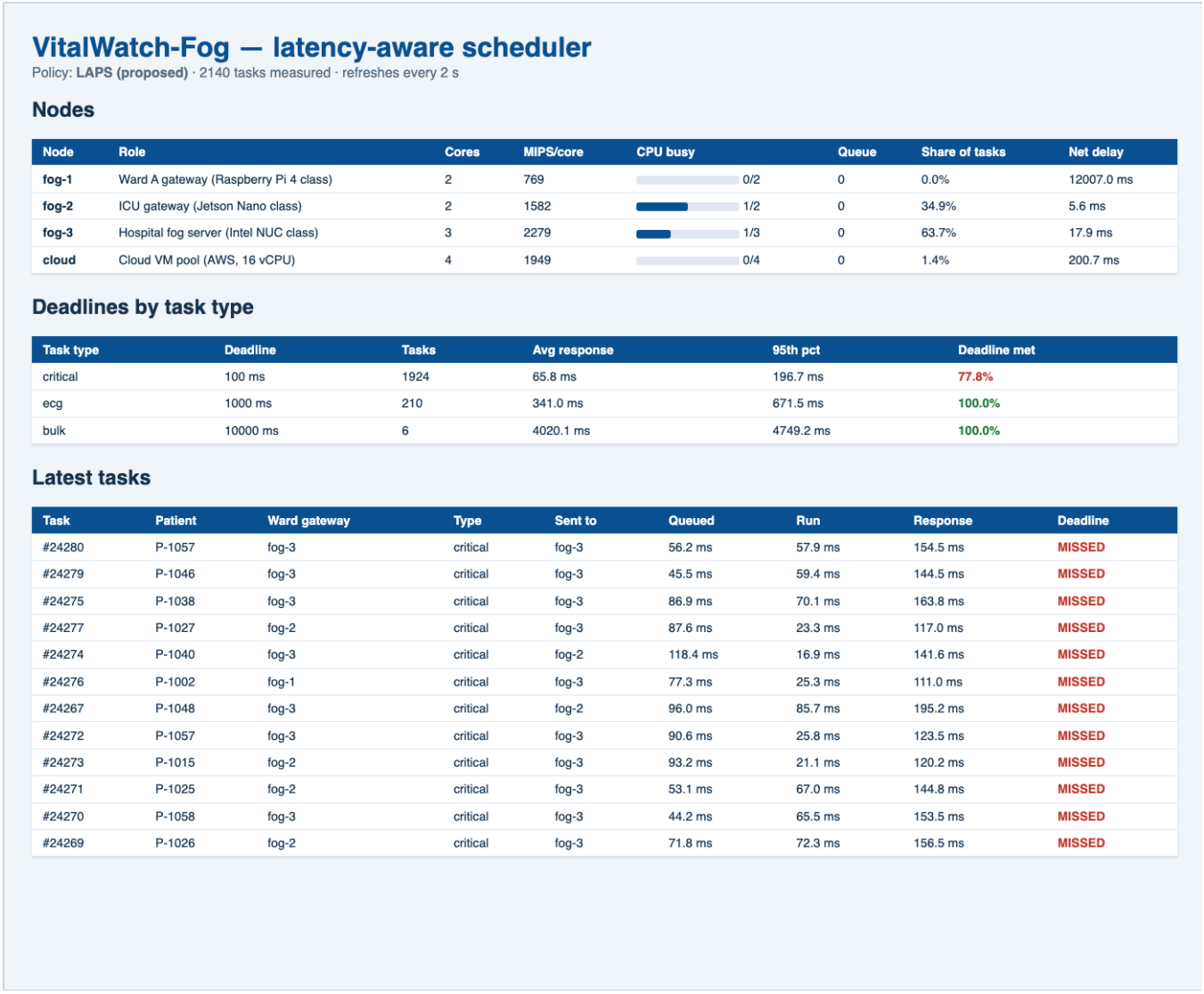
$ docker compose up -d
$ docker compose ps
NAME               IMAGE                           STATUS
cia2-cloud-1       shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1   Up 9 minutes (healthy)
cia2-cloud-wan-1   shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1   Up 9 minutes
cia2-fog-1-1       shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1   Up 9 minutes (healthy)
cia2-fog-2-1       shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1   Up 9 minutes (healthy)
cia2-fog-3-1       shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1   Up 9 minutes (healthy)
cia2-gateway-1     shakthe1311/vitalwatch-fog:v1   Up 9 minutes (healthy)

$ docker compose logs | grep ready
fog-1-1   | fog-1 ready: 2 cores, 619 MIPS per core
fog-2-1   | fog-2 ready: 2 cores, 1581 MIPS per core
fog-3-1   | fog-3 ready: 3 cores, 2403 MIPS per core
cloud-1   | cloud ready: 4 cores, 2503 MIPS per core
cloud-wan-1 | qdisc netem 8004: root refcnt 11 limit 1000 delay 70ms  10ms

$ docker compose exec gateway python -c "...ping /health 5 times..."
http://cloud:8000/health [150.3, 73.3, 72.0, 74.1, 76.8]   (ms)
http://fog-3:8000/health [4.4, 1.7, 1.3, 1.0, 0.9]        (ms)
```

Figure 6.1 — building the image, starting the testbed, each node's self-measured speed, and the emulated WAN delay to the cloud

Then I started 60 patients' wearables for 45 s with `docker compose run --rm wearables --patients 60 --duration 45` and opened the gateway dashboard:



VitalWatch-Fog — latency-aware scheduler

Policy: **LAPS (proposed)** · 2140 tasks measured · refreshes every 2 s

Nodes

Node	Role	Cores	MIPS/core	CPU busy	Queue	Share of tasks	Net delay
fog-1	Ward A gateway (Raspberry Pi 4 class)	2	769	0/2	0	0.0%	12007.0 ms
fog-2	ICU gateway (Jetson Nano class)	2	1582	1/2	0	34.9%	5.6 ms
fog-3	Hospital fog server (Intel NUC class)	3	2279	1/3	0	63.7%	17.9 ms
cloud	Cloud VM pool (AWS, 16 vCPU)	4	1949	0/4	0	1.4%	200.7 ms

Deadlines by task type

Task type	Deadline	Tasks	Avg response	95th pct	Deadline met
critical	100 ms	1924	65.8 ms	196.7 ms	77.8%
ecg	1000 ms	210	341.0 ms	671.5 ms	100.0%
bulk	10000 ms	6	4020.1 ms	4749.2 ms	100.0%

Latest tasks

Task	Patient	Ward gateway	Type	Sent to	Queued	Run	Response	Deadline
#24280	P-1057	fog-3	critical	fog-3	56.2 ms	57.9 ms	154.5 ms	MISSED
#24279	P-1046	fog-3	critical	fog-3	45.5 ms	59.4 ms	144.5 ms	MISSED
#24275	P-1038	fog-3	critical	fog-3	86.9 ms	70.1 ms	163.8 ms	MISSED
#24277	P-1027	fog-2	critical	fog-3	87.6 ms	23.3 ms	117.0 ms	MISSED
#24274	P-1040	fog-3	critical	fog-2	118.4 ms	16.9 ms	141.6 ms	MISSED
#24276	P-1002	fog-1	critical	fog-3	77.3 ms	25.3 ms	111.0 ms	MISSED
#24267	P-1048	fog-3	critical	fog-2	96.0 ms	85.7 ms	195.2 ms	MISSED
#24272	P-1057	fog-3	critical	fog-3	90.6 ms	25.8 ms	123.5 ms	MISSED
#24273	P-1015	fog-2	critical	fog-3	93.2 ms	21.1 ms	120.2 ms	MISSED
#24271	P-1025	fog-2	critical	fog-3	53.1 ms	67.0 ms	144.8 ms	MISSED
#24270	P-1058	fog-3	critical	fog-3	44.2 ms	65.5 ms	153.5 ms	MISSED
#24269	P-1026	fog-2	critical	fog-3	71.8 ms	72.3 ms	156.5 ms	MISSED

Figure 6.2 — live gateway dashboard under load: node CPU use, queues, share of tasks, deadline results per task type and the latest tasks

Over this live run 3012 tasks were measured. All 284 ECG tasks and all 8 bulk jobs met their deadlines. 80.3% of the 2720 critical checks met 100 ms (average 61.6 ms). LAPS put 63.5% of tasks on fog-3, 35.3% on fog-2 and 1.2% on the cloud. It sent nothing to fog-1: at 619 MIPS per core a critical check alone takes about 80 ms there, so it could not safely meet the deadline. The live result is lower than the simulator's because a laptop adds costs the simulator does not have: HTTP and Python overhead on every task, and Docker CPU limits that slow a container down in bursts. I still think the testbed is useful. It shows the same code making the same kind of choices on real containers with a real network delay.

7. Results Under Varying Workloads

All graphs below come from the simulator, as the average of 5 seeds, with 50 to 300 patients.

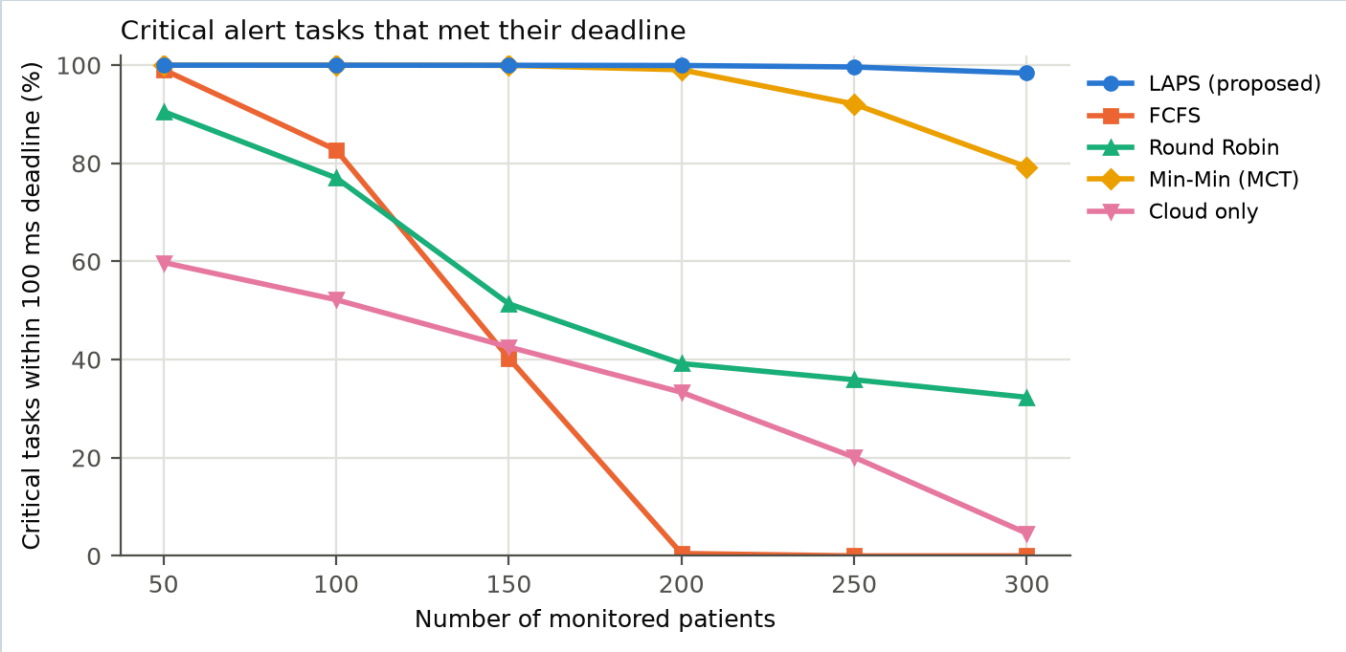


Figure 7.1 — critical tasks that met the 100 ms deadline

This is the most important graph. LAPS stays at 98.4% or above all the way to 300 patients. Min-Min is close until 200 patients and then drops to 79.3%. With FIFO queues, a critical task waits behind long ECG and bulk jobs. FCFS falls apart once the Pi gateway in Ward A is full (around 100–150 patients), and Round Robin fails for the same reason, since it keeps sending a quarter of all work to the slowest node. Cloud-only is bad even at 50 patients (59.8%), because a 70 ms round trip plus queueing on the uplink leaves almost no room inside 100 ms.

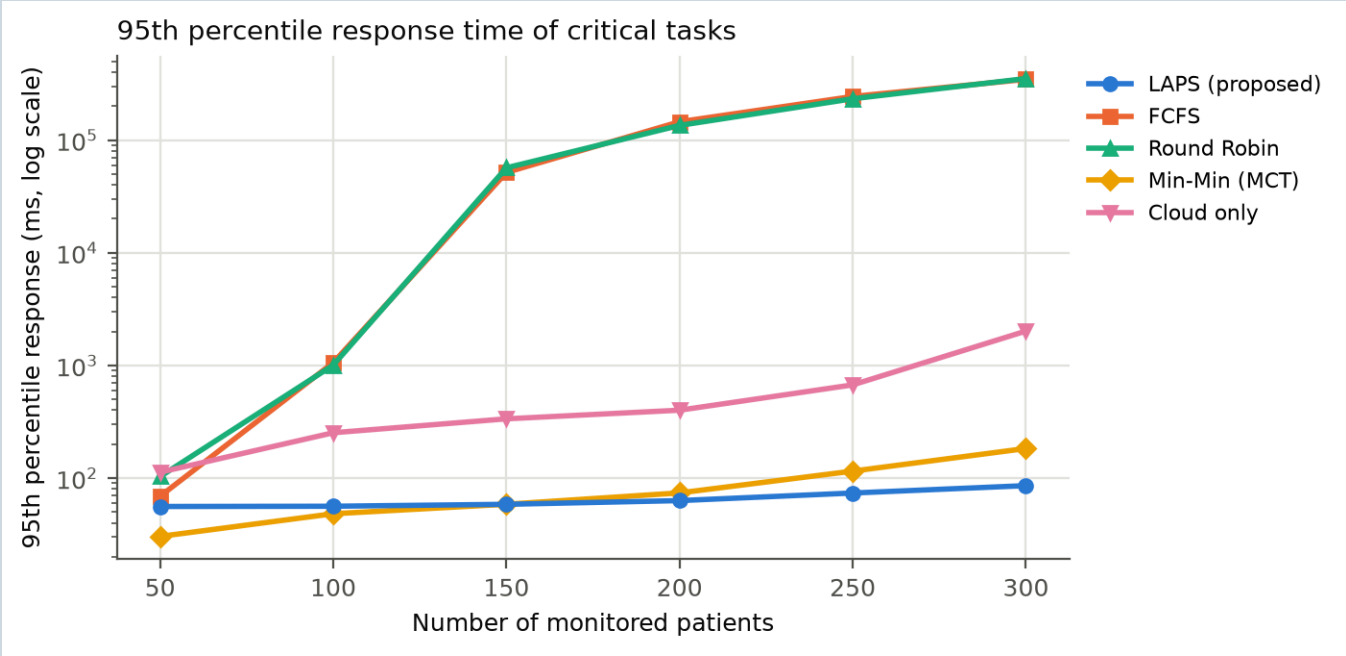


Figure 7.2 — 95th percentile response time of critical tasks (log scale)

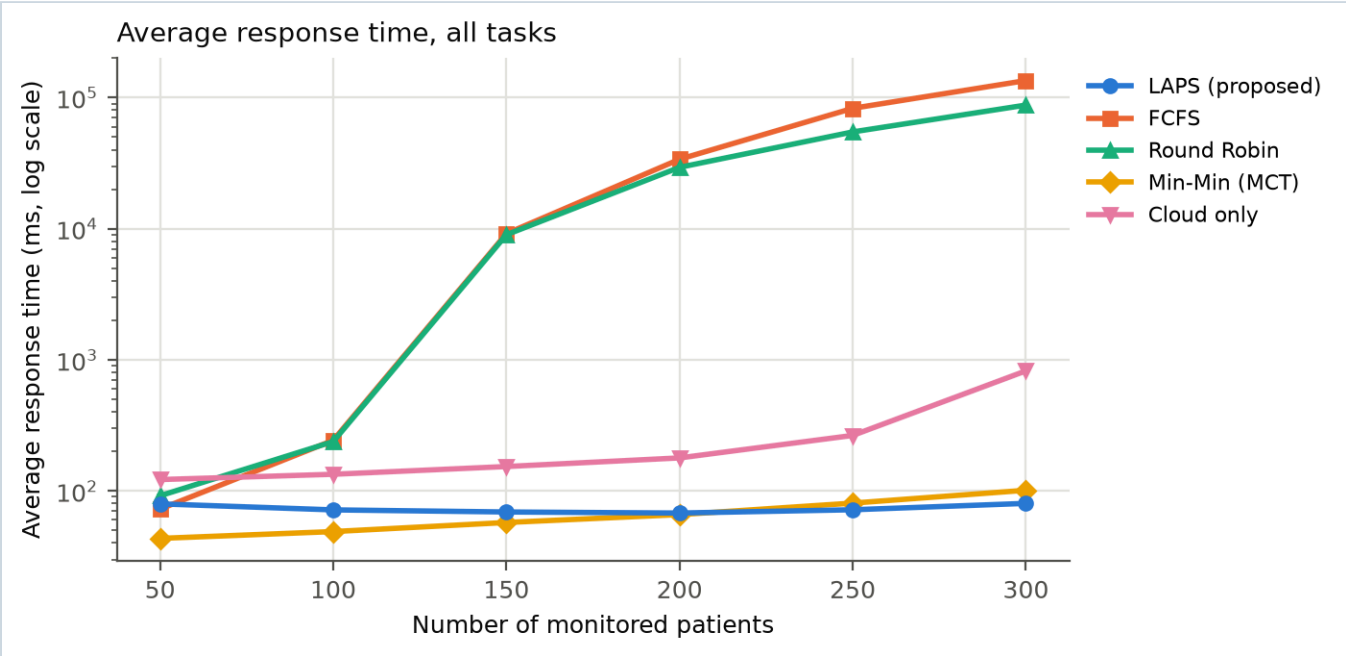


Figure 7.3 — average response time of all tasks (log scale)

At 300 patients, 95% of LAPS critical tasks finish within 85.5 ms. For Min-Min the figure is 182.7 ms and for cloud-only 2014 ms. FCFS and Round Robin queues grow without limit, so their averages reach tens of seconds.

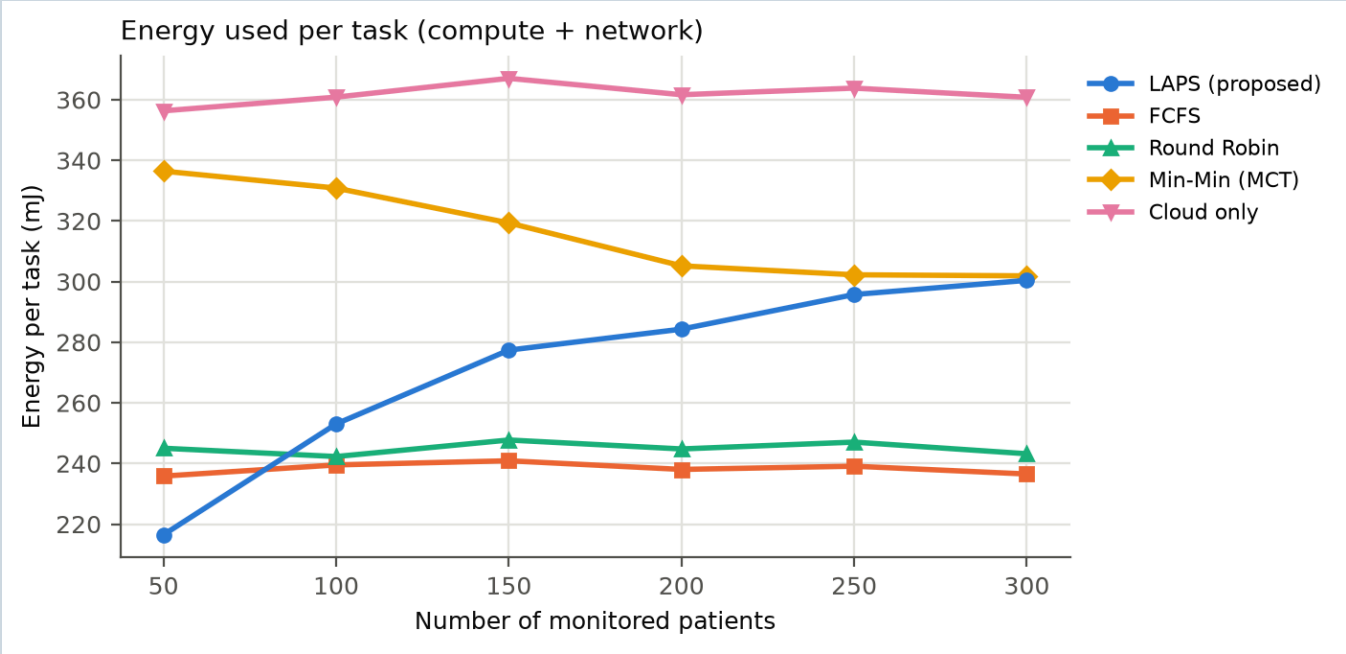


Figure 7.4 — energy per task

At light load LAPS uses the least energy of all five (216 mJ per task at 50 patients, against 336 mJ for Min-Min and 356 mJ for cloud-only). It keeps work on the small, efficient fog boards while they have room. At 300 patients it is level with Min-Min (300 vs 302 mJ). FCFS looks cheaper at high load only because it never uses the cloud, and it misses almost every deadline.

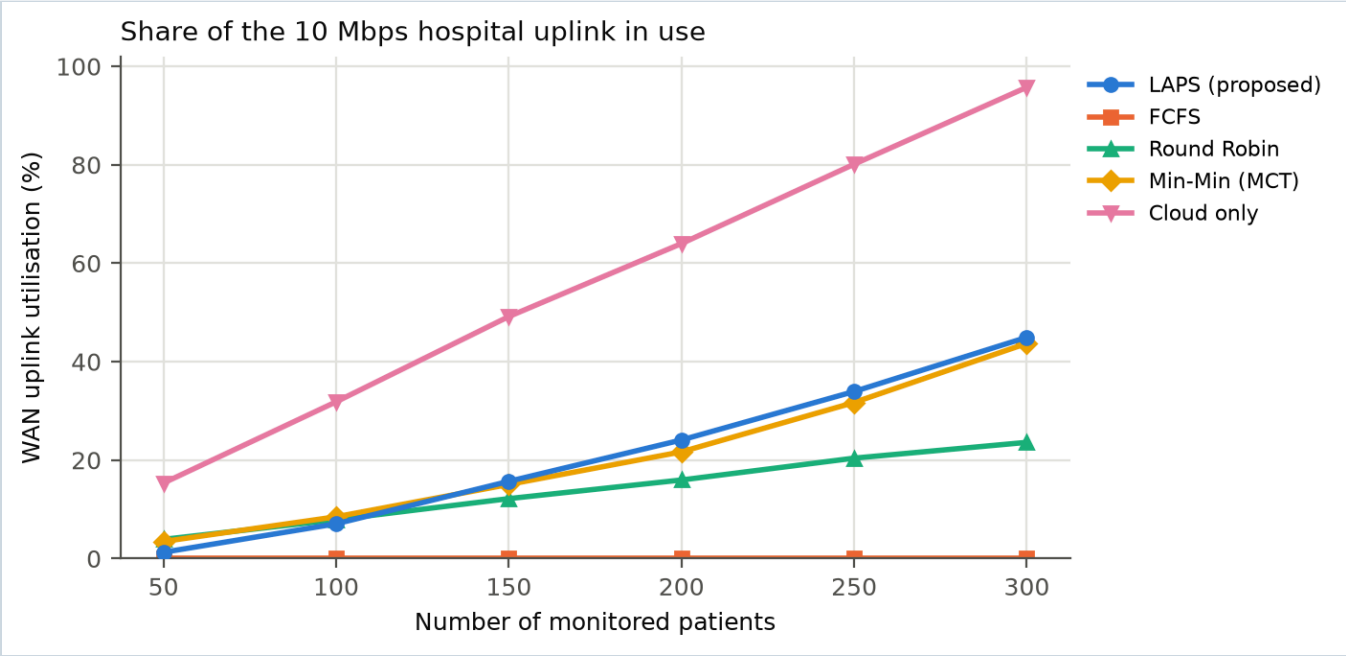


Figure 7.5 — use of the 10 Mbps hospital uplink

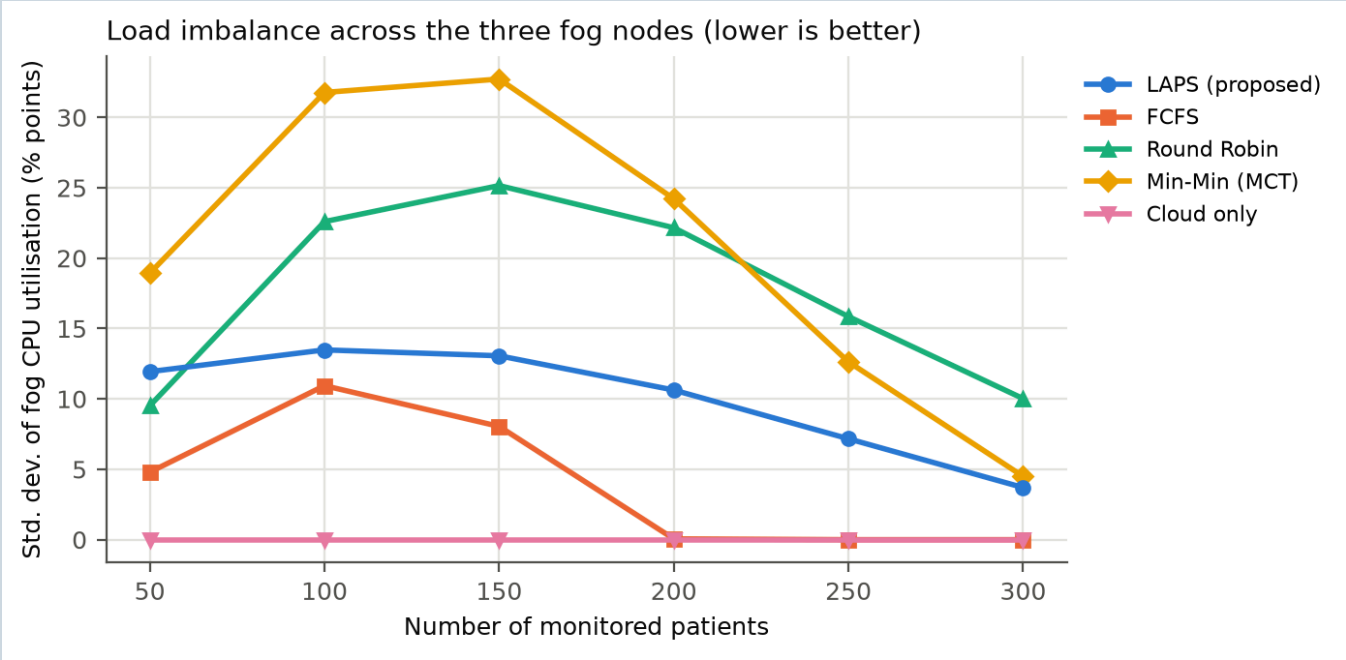


Figure 7.6 — load imbalance between the three fog nodes (standard deviation of CPU use)

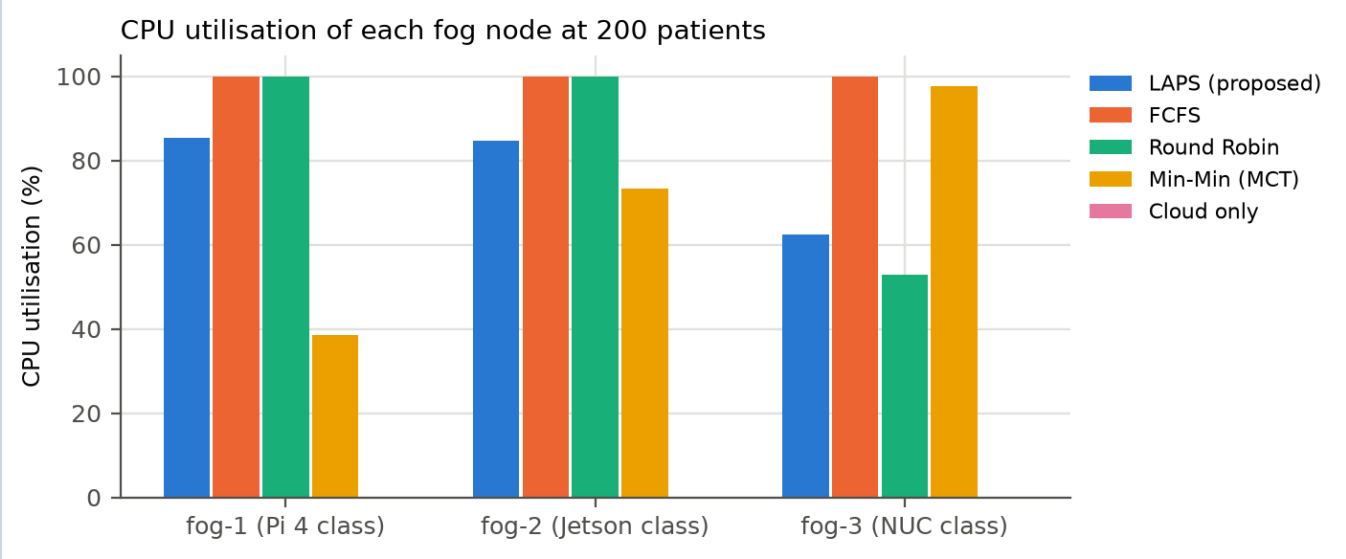


Figure 7.7 — CPU use of each fog node at 200 patients

Cloud-only fills 95.8% of the uplink at 300 patients. LAPS needs 44.9%, mostly for bulk jobs, which leaves room for other hospital traffic. Min-Min piles work onto the fast NUC: at 150 patients the imbalance is 32.7 points against 13.1 for LAPS. LAPS spreads the load because the CPU-load term pushes tasks away from a busy node.

Emergency burst

To test a sudden change in load, I ran 150 patients and, between 120 s and 180 s, made 20% of them "emergency" patients. They send vitals five times as often and ECG ten times as often.

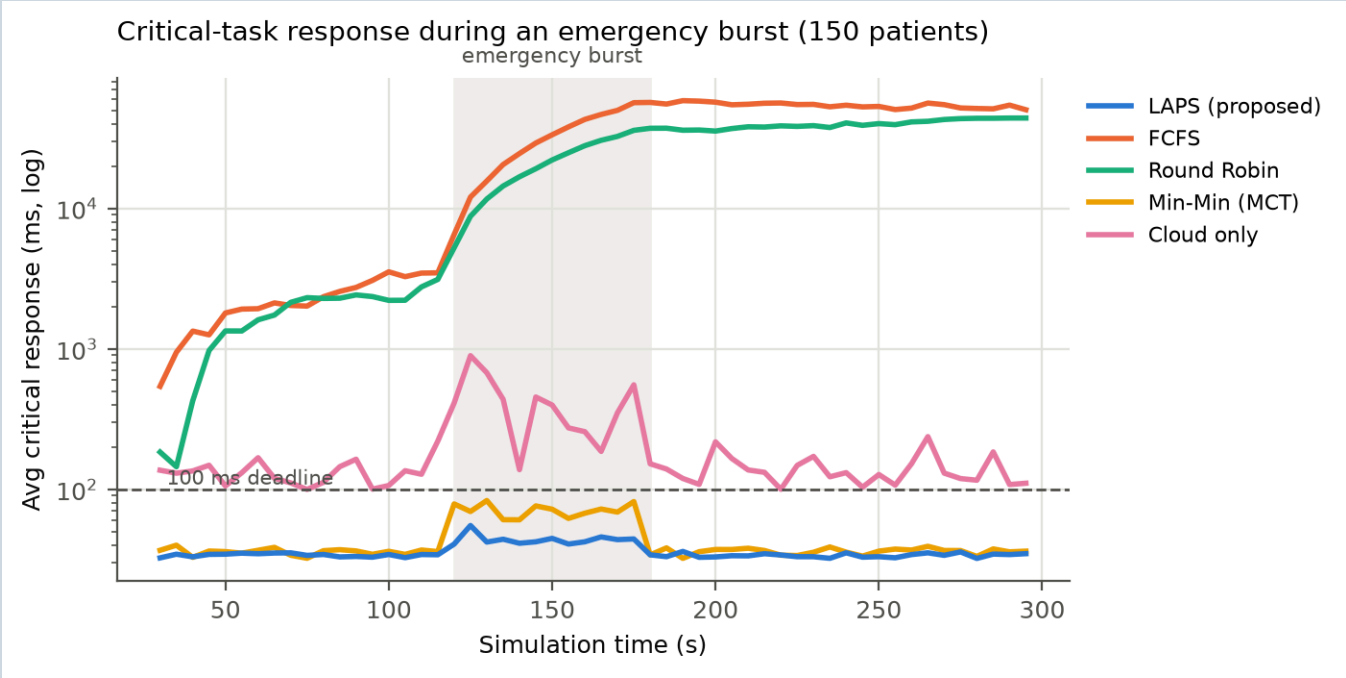


Figure 7.8 — average critical response time in 5-second steps during the burst

LAPS rises only slightly, stays far below 100 ms, and meets 99.9% of critical deadlines over the run. Min-Min gets close to the deadline line during the burst (94.9% met). Cloud-only spikes to almost a second, and FCFS and Round Robin never recover after the burst ends.

Which part of LAPS matters? (300 patients)

Version	Critical deadline met	Critical p95	Energy per task
LAPS (full)	98.4%	85.5 ms	300 mJ
without the energy term	99.4%	68.4 ms	314 mJ
without core reservation	97.9%	88.2 ms	301 mJ
FIFO queues instead of priority queues	94.3%	103.4 ms	301 mJ

The priority queue gives the largest gain. The core reservation adds a little at this load. The energy term costs about one point of critical deadlines at 300 patients but saves about 4.6% energy, which brings me to the trade-off.

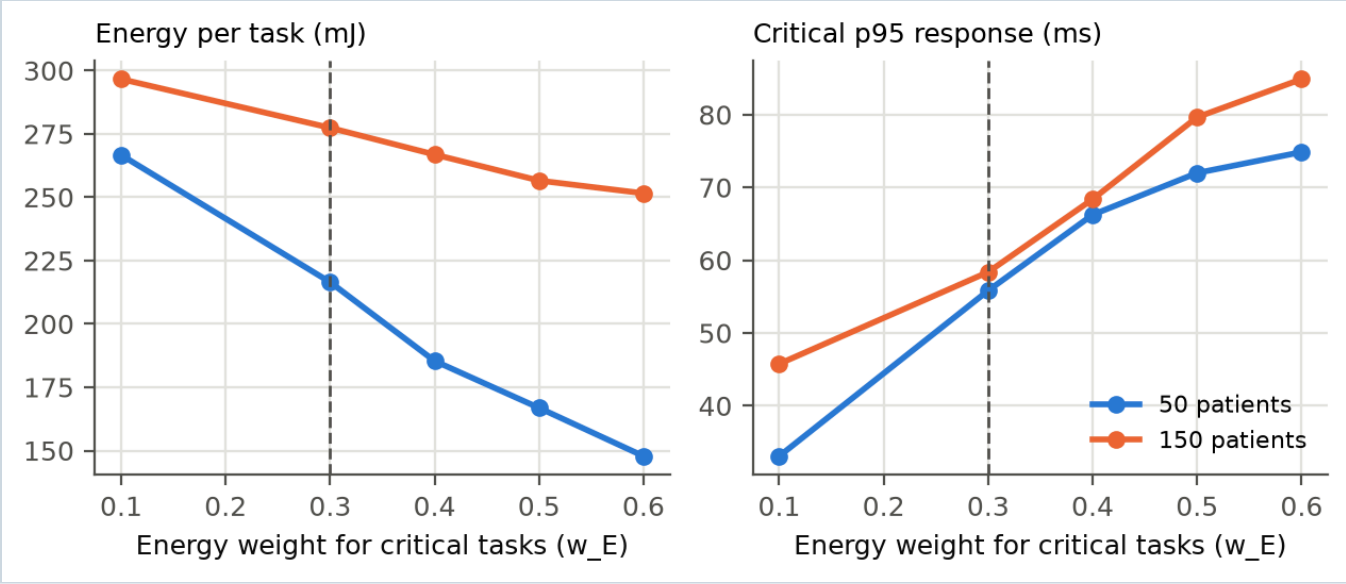


Figure 7.9 — changing the energy weight for critical tasks: energy against latency (dashed line = the value I chose)

Raising the energy weight from 0.1 to 0.6 cuts energy per task at 50 patients from 266 mJ to 148 mJ, but the critical p95 rises from 33 ms to 75 ms. All of these settings still meet the deadline at light load, so the weight is a real knob between battery and power use on one side and safety margin on the other. I chose 0.3: it saves a good amount of energy and keeps the p95 well under 100 ms even at 300 patients.

8. Comparison and Justification

Method	Critical met at 50 / 300 patients	Main problem
FCFS (local)	99.1% / 0%	no offloading; the slowest gateway overloads first
Round Robin	90.5% / 32.3%	ignores node speed, load and the deadline
Min-Min (MCT)	100% / 79.3%	FIFO queues: urgent tasks wait behind long jobs; overloads the fastest node
Cloud only	59.8% / 4.6%	WAN round trip and a full uplink
LAPS	**100% / 98.4%**	a bit more energy than FCFS at high load (but FCFS misses its deadlines)

Why I think this design suits a hospital:

- **Urgent work stays near the patient.** Critical checks almost never go to the cloud, so a slow or broken internet link does not stop alerts.
- **Heavy work goes where it is cheap.** When the fog is quiet, bulk jobs run on the efficient boards. When it is busy, they move to the cloud, where a 10 s deadline is easy to meet.
- **It is simple.** One decision costs a few arithmetic steps per node, unlike ACO, GA or RL schedulers that must be trained or iterated. It fits on a Raspberry Pi gateway.
- **It uses all six parameters the question asks for**, in one decision for every task.

Limitations

- The main comparison is from my own simulator. The node speeds, power figures and energy per bit are assumptions taken from typical device specs, not measured on real hardware.
- The simulator assumes each gateway knows the current state of all nodes. In the testbed this comes from the gateway's own records, and its estimates were less accurate (80.3% live vs 99.9% simulated at a similar load).
- Tasks are never stopped once started (no pre-emption), and patients do not move between wards.
- I tried the baselines on the testbed too. At 60 patients they overloaded the load generator's and nodes' thread pools, so their numbers measured my test tool rather than the schedulers. I left them out of this report.

9. Conclusion and Future Work

I extended VitalWatch from a cloud-only system into a three-layer fog system and designed LAPS, a latency-aware scheduler with load balancing. LAPS decides every task using its priority, deadline, estimated latency, CPU load, link bandwidth and energy. In 225 simulation runs it kept critical alerts within 100 ms for 98.4–100% of tasks from 50 to 300 patients. Under the same load the best conventional method (Min-Min) dropped to 79.3% and cloud-only to 4.6%. LAPS used the least energy at light load, needed less than half of the uplink, and handled an emergency burst with almost no change. The same scheduler code also runs on a live Docker testbed with real CPU work and real network delay.

Future work:

- Make the weights change on their own: more energy saving when the fog is quiet, more latency focus when it is busy.
- Add pre-emption so a critical check can pause a bulk job.
- Support patients moving between wards (task hand-off between fog nodes).
- Share node state with a small gossip protocol so the estimates stay fresh.
- Run the fog layer on real Raspberry Pi and Jetson boards with K3s.

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